Nutrient cycles Feed the soil

Make compost, gather seaweed where permitted, and grow peas and beans to capture nitrogen from the air. Return useful material to the soil, then rotate crops to make good use of it.

All crops need these nutrients; the examples below show some particular benefits.

Nutrient	What it does · crops helped	Capture, store and use it
N **Nitrogen**	Leaf and shoot growth: kale, cabbage, spinach and other leafy greens.	Leave healthy pea and bean roots. Compost the tops and follow with leafy greens.
P **Phosphorus**	Root development and energy transfer: all crops, including young transplants.	Recycle plant waste through compost. Test the soil before adding extra phosphorus.
K **Potassium**	Water balance and crop quality: tomatoes, cucumbers and potatoes.	Grow Bocking 14 comfrey in a permanent patch. Let it establish, then compost cut leaves to return their potassium to growing beds.
Micronutrients	Healthy growth in all crops; iron and boron are needed in tiny amounts.	Return trace nutrients with varied compost ingredients and seaweed. Most soils already have enough.



1 · Beans and peas before leafy greens

After early broad beans, plant kale. Bacteria in the bean root nodules capture nitrogen from the air. Cut spent plants at the base, leaving healthy roots; compost the tops. As the remains decay, some nitrogen feeds the following crop. Peas work in the same way; add mature compost where needed.



2 · Turn plant waste into plant food

Mix green waste and peelings with shredded cardboard and woody trimmings. Keep damp, not soaked; spread on beds once dark and crumbly. Compost adds nutrients and carbon-rich organic matter. Its humus helps hold water and nutrients; plants get carbon from the air.



3 · Bring in seaweed and trace nutrients

After winter storms, gather loose, washed-up seaweed where permitted, leaving plenty for shore wildlife. Remove plastic and spread on empty beds to decay before planting. It adds potassium, trace nutrients and organic matter. Treat a few beds, then different ones next winter.

John's compost and seaweed videos. Additional advice: Garden Organic, RHS.